

type-certified drone technology for agriculture. Its pesticide-carrying drones feature lightweight, easily interchangeable tanks designed for quick handling without external tools. Flying Wedge drones boast of a sturdy design, utilising aluminium and carbon fibre instead of plastic, enhancing airframe lifespan and crash durability. They are modular, portable, and easily reconfigurable for various use cases. A two-wheeler with a box case replaces the need for multiple people, large vehicles, and diesel, reducing operational costs. Equipped with auto-flight safety checks and mandatory health monitoring, these drones offer autonomous flights with built-in workflows and user-friendly interfaces.

Q. What are the types of drones Flying Wedge produces?

Flying Wedge was launched in February 2022, beginning with catcher drones which were supplied to L&T. We view this as a breakthrough and a milestone in our journey. From there, we developed the best-in-class agricultural and defence drones. We proudly hold a monopoly in the unique catcher and killer drone market. Our surveillance drones are actively guarding India's borders and critical personnel.

Q. How will this USP affect Flying Wedge's customers, and why should it matter to them?

Our cost reduction and innovative techniques will undoubtedly impact the drone industry. The modular nature will increase our drones' popularity and ease of management. This will give us an edge over competitors who import drones as CKD and assemble them in India. Farmers will find our drones more comfortable to use with swappable tanks. Customers prioritise cost, comfort, and service, so they highly value our unique selling proposition (USP).

Q. What were the challenges Flying Wedge faced in developing this USP?

The first challenge was understanding what our competitors offered and making our strength and business model as our USP. Our target customers needed a cost-effective, easy-to-handle solution, and we had to work

towards that. Initially, we used plastic for internal parts and components like the folding mechanism which holds the motor and the arm. This mechanism undergoes maximum stress, and redesigning it to aluminium while maintaining precision was challenging. Similarly, we worked towards a swappable pesticide tank and successfully achieved it. Our software was initially open-source, but later, we developed our customised software and firmware that is simple and stable. It is indeed a bold attempt to invest a huge amount of money in developing technology as a startup. We had no flying object type certified in India to look for a reference when we started, and we had to completely depend on foreign technologies, be it manned airplanes or unmanned aircraft. We wanted to change this and have a technology of our own to make India proud. The initial days of R&D were quite disappointing. The entire team struggled for about a year and finally achieved it. We are now India's first and only type-certified indigenous unmanned aircraft technology company for the agriculture sector. Raising funds for R&D was the biggest challenge that we faced. Nobody was willing to believe in a group of youngsters trying out a new technology and a new product. At every stage, we had to prove ourselves and establish our competence.

Q. For which categories of drones have you partnered with TESCO?

Currently, we have partnered with TESCO for agricultural drones. We are sure of a long-term relationship where we also intend to extend the collaboration for defence drones. We have also partnered with TESCO in the agricultural sector, showcasing drones as a service to the farmers.

Q. What key reasons prompted Flying Wedge to partner with TESCO?

Flying Wedge is phenomenally good at research and technology. We were looking for an exceptionally good partner with expertise in electronics manufacturing and assembly. TESCO's managing director, V. Balasubramani, and director, Nandini, come with a combined experience of more than 50 years in the industry.



PRAJWAL BHAT, Co-founder, Flying Wedge

They have been instrumental in building the Electronic City ecosystem. Balasubramani's entrepreneurial capacity and risk-taking ability is very high, and they greatly aid in developing new ideas and projects.

We believe the relationship between an organisation and its supplier should go beyond simple buying and selling. It should have synergy in trust-building and alignment of goals. With TESCO, we have found the comfort of managing the business and planning for risk management activities together. This has resulted in improvement in all sectors and helps Flying Wedge stay ahead of the curve. The strategic partnership is also helping in significant cost reduction. Also, TESCO has served as a crucial lifeline during supply chain disruptions, offering alternate sources of supply or stepping in as contingency partners. This partnership ensures business continuity and fortifies the organisation's resilience in the face of unforeseen challenges.

Q. Do you have similar partnerships with other manufacturers for other categories of drones?

We've partnered with the Electronic City Industries Association (ELCIA) Cluster. We manufacture the mechanical components at the ELCA Cluster, which is also under the supervision of TESCO. This unique consortium is